RESILIENT FUTURES LAB

03

Digital safety and scam prevention

Protect money, accounts and identity

Messages and links	**Account security**
Jobs and grants	**Verify and respond**

A learning booklet Resilient Futures Lab

Choose the route that fits your experience.

Work through the examples, discuss your reasoning, and complete the final case. A calculator, paper and a pencil are enough.

English edition October 2026

EUonAIR project

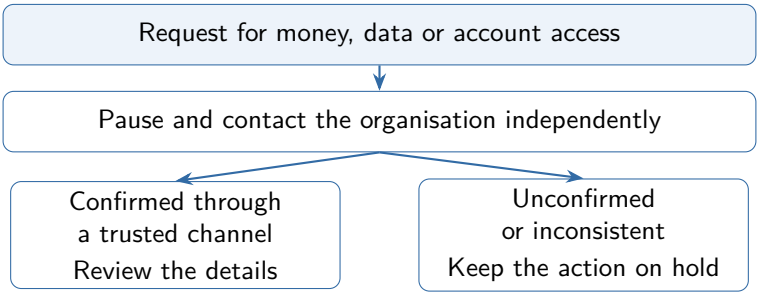
01 A USEFUL PAUSE

Check the request

A message can borrow a familiar logo, a friend's name or a teacher's photograph. **Social engineering** uses trust, pressure or curiosity to persuade someone to reveal information or take an unsafe action. [S2]

A classroom example

A message announces a travel grant and asks for a payment within ten minutes. The useful first question is: *What action does this message want from me?* Identify the requested money, information or access before considering the story.



Use a contact already held in your address book, a saved official app or a verified institutional website. A telephone number supplied inside the suspicious message belongs to the same unverified story. Warning signs help you pause; polished presentation also needs verification.

Try it 1. A grant message supplies a "verification hotline". Explain how you would find an independent contact instead.

02 MESSAGES AND WEBSITES

Follow the evidence

Phishing uses deceptive messages or websites to collect information or gain access. A text-message version is often called *smishing*. Familiar branding and fluent language can appear in fraudulent messages. [S2]

A documented case in Ukraine

On 20 November 2023, Ukraine's Ministry of Internal Affairs reported an investigation in the Kharkiv region. Suspects had circulated links to pages resembling state-bank websites, offering social assistance and collecting payment-card information. This is an account of an investigation, with suspects identified in the official report. [S3]

Simulated message

Your education payment is ready. Confirm your account today at `student-support.example`.

Three checks

Who runs the programme?

Does its official page announce this payment?

Why is the form asking for banking access?

The address above is reserved for examples. In practice, open the institution's established website or app yourself. Read the full address carefully. A secure-connection symbol tells you about the connection; the organisation and request still need checking.

Try it 2. A friend forwards the message. What can you ask the friend, and which independent source could confirm the programme?

03 ACCOUNTS AND DEVICES

Protect access and recovery

An email account can receive password-reset messages for many other services. Protecting it helps protect those connected accounts too.

Use a long, unique password for each account; a reputable password manager can store these. Where available, use a **passkey**, which links sign-in to the genuine service and can resist phishing. [S1]

1. **Sign in**
   Unique password or passkey
2. **Confirm**
   Extra authentication where available
3. **Recover**
   Protected recovery details and backup codes
4. **Maintain**
   Updates and account activity checks

Multi-factor authentication adds another check when signing in. Prefer a security key, passkey or authenticator app when suitable options exist. Keep verification codes private and approve only requests you initiated. Apply software updates and check recovery details. [S1]

Try it 3. A sign-in approval arrives while you are eating lunch. You have started no login. What should you do?

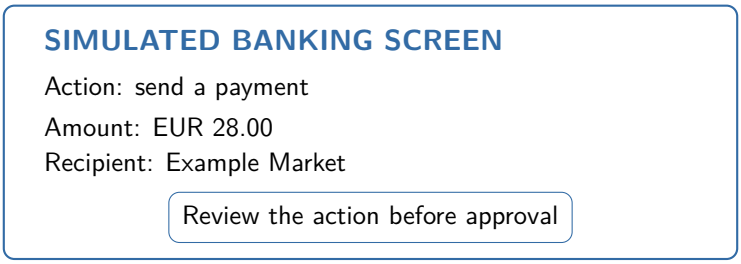
Further practice | ages 18–24

Plan recovery for a lost phone: identify the provider's recovery route and a secure place for backup codes. Write only the plan (keep real credentials private).

04 PAYMENTS

Read what you authorise

Payment approval should follow your own decision to pay. Read the amount, currency and recipient shown in your banking app. A request to "confirm a refund" can conceal a request to send money.



If you expected to receive a refund, the screen above conflicts with that expectation. Stop the transaction and reach your bank through its established app or official telephone number.

The National Bank of Ukraine's 2023 payment-security materials advise keeping banking passwords, card security codes and one-time codes private. They also recommend calling back on the bank's official number and promptly blocking an exposed card. [S5]

Try it 4. A caller says a one-time bank code will release your scholarship. Explain why you would keep the code private and whom you would contact.

Further practice | ages 18–24

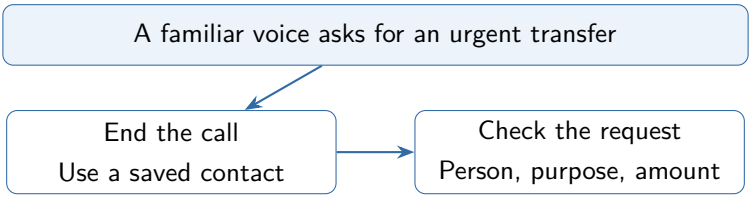
For an online purchase, compare the checkout order with the bank's approval screen: merchant, amount and currency. Stop if the details differ.

05 VOICES AND VIDEO

Verify a familiar face

A **deepfake** is synthetic or altered media that can imitate a person's appearance or voice. It can make a request feel familiar even when its origin remains uncertain.

On 19 October 2026, INTERPOL launched a public campaign about deepfake-enabled scams. Its examples included apparent calls from colleagues requesting transfers and calls imitating family members. Its advice emphasised checking through an independently known channel. [S6]



A classroom example

A voice message appears to come from a youth-club coordinator: "Please pay the venue deposit now." Call the coordinator using the number already held by the club. If contact is unavailable, keep the payment on hold and ask another authorised organiser.

Visual or audio irregularities can raise questions. Clear sound and smooth video also need verification. A real colleague's account may itself be compromised.

Try it 5. Write a two-sentence message to the genuine coordinator asking them to confirm the payment through the club's usual process.

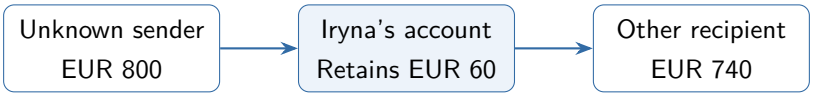
06 WORK AND INCOME

Recognise a money-mule offer

A **money mule** receives and moves funds for another person, helping to conceal where criminal proceeds came from. Recruitment can resemble an ordinary job advertisement. Europol's guidance identifies students and newcomers among targeted groups. [S4]

A classroom example

A supposed online employer offers Iryna, aged 21, a "payment assistant" role. She must receive EUR 800, transfer EUR 740 to another account and retain EUR 60. The employer gives vague answers about the business and the work.



The personal account is being used to move someone else's money. The promised commission leaves the account holder exposed to serious consequences. Decline this arrangement. If funds have already arrived, stop transfers, contact the bank and report the concern to local police; let the bank guide any return. [S4]

Try it 6. Calculate the promised commission as a percentage of the incoming amount. Identify the feature that makes this offer unsafe.

Further practice | ages 18–24

List three details to verify for a genuine job: employer identity, duties and employment terms. Explain why a professional-looking contract alone cannot settle these checks.

07 GRANTS AND DONATIONS

Check the organisation

Scholarships, community collections and training opportunities often circulate through friends. Their purpose deserves attention, and their identity and payment arrangements deserve checking.

Before sharing data or sending money

1. Find the programme through its established institution.
2. Check published eligibility, dates and application steps.
3. Confirm the named organiser and payment recipient.
4. Ask why each requested item of information is needed.

A classroom comparison

A youth-centre donation page names an organiser, a collection goal and a published contact. A forwarded message uses the same logo and directs donations to a different account. Call the centre using its established contact before paying or forwarding either request.

A request for a passport copy can be relevant at a verified stage of an exchange programme. Share only the required information through the institution's confirmed process. A request for an email password or a bank approval code should trigger an immediate pause.

The Ukrainian investigation on page 3 shows how genuine assistance programmes can be imitated. [S3] The habit of independent contact also applies to fundraising and scholarships. [S2]

Try it 7. A scholarship form asks for your school, age range and email password. Which field exposes account access? How would you check the application route?

08 AFTER A MISTAKE

Act promptly and get support

Scams use timing, trust and pressure. A calm response helps limit further exposure. A trusted adult, teacher or support worker can help a younger learner take the next steps.

Payment or card exposed
Contact the bank through its official channel

Password exposed
Secure the account through its genuine service

Evidence available
Keep messages and transaction details privately

Support and reporting
Contact local police and the relevant platform

For a payment or exposed card, ask the bank about blocking access and any available transaction-recovery steps. Outcomes depend on the circumstances. [S5] [S6]

For an exposed password, change it through the genuine service and change reused copies. Review signed-in devices and recovery details, and enable suitable additional authentication. Warn contacts if someone used your account to message them. [S1] [S2]

Keep screenshots, times and receipts for official reports. Avoid publishing sensitive evidence. Use local or national police channels in the country where you are; in Ukraine, use the official Cyber Police service. [S4]

Try it 8. Someone entered a password into a suspicious page and then closed it. Name the first two account-protection actions.

Further practice | ages 18–24

Prepare an offline contact plan containing your bank's official contact route and an institutional support contact. Keep account secrets separate.

SOURCES

Evidence and further reading

These sources support the explanations and documented examples. Classroom characters, messages and amounts are fictional. The links below lead to official guidance or institutional reports. Sources checked on 30 October 2026.

[S1] ENISA, accessed 2026. Cyber Hygiene. Passwords, passkeys, additional authentication, updates and account checks.

[S2] Council of the European Union, 2025. Cybersecurity social engineering. Definitions, independent contact and response advice.

[S3] Ministry of Internal Affairs of Ukraine, 2023. Fraud under the guise of social payments. Kharkiv investigation reported on 20 November.

[S4] Europol, updated 2025. Money Muling. Recruitment, warning signs and response guidance.

[S5] National Bank of Ukraine, 2023. Payment security basic tips. Teaching material from the GoodbyeToFraud campaign.

[S6] INTERPOL, 2026. Public awareness campaign on AI deepfake scams. Launched on 19 October.

FINAL CASE READ AND DECIDE

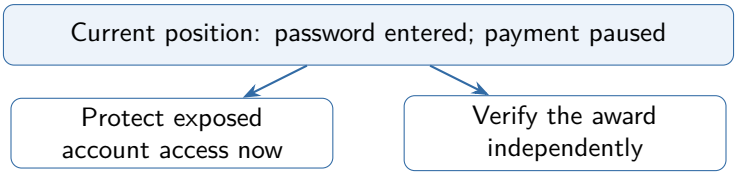
An exchange offer arrives

Fictional classroom case. All names, messages and amounts are invented. Work with the information provided.

Olena, aged 17, is preparing for a school exchange. At 17:40, a message in a class chat announces a EUR 400 "EU Youth Travel Award". It asks for a EUR 20 processing fee by 18:00 through `grant-check.example`. A logo resembles the school's logo.

The form requests her usual email password and says a bank code will "confirm the payment". Olena enters the email password, then pauses before giving any banking information or paying. She has used that same password on another account.

A voice message sounds like the exchange coordinator and urges her to finish quickly. The school's published exchange page contains no mention of this award. The genuine coordinator can be reached through the school office the next morning.



A linked opportunity. Nazar, aged 21, receives a "project assistant" offer from the same sender. He would receive EUR 900, forward EUR 840 and keep EUR 60. The sender gives no clear work duties.

FINAL CASE YOUR RESPONSE

Explain your decisions

Use short sentences and show the calculation. Questions 1–6 form the core task. Question 7 extends the case for ages 18–24.

1. Identify three warning signs in Olena's offer. Explain what each makes you question.

2. Describe an independent way to check the award. What should happen while confirmation is unavailable?

3. Explain why the familiar voice and school logo leave the request's identity uncertain.

4. State three actions Olena should take after exposing a reused password.

5. Explain how Olena should handle the requested bank code. Name an appropriate source of support.

6. Draft a two-sentence message to the genuine school coordinator asking about the award.

7. Calculate Nazar's promised commission as a percentage of EUR 900. Explain the money-mule warning sign and give his next action.